490.LIFE · THE WHOLE STORY · LESSON 26 OF 26

Revelation and the New Creation

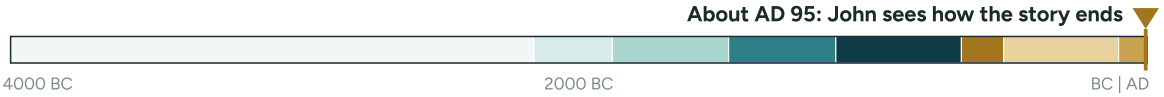
Revelation 1; 4–5; 21–22



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YOU ARE HERE · LESSON 26



Introduction: How the Story Ends

Twenty-five lessons ago we started on the road to Emmaus, where the risen Jesus walked with two discouraged disciples and, "beginning with Moses and all the Prophets, he interpreted to them in all the Scriptures the things concerning himself" (Luke 24:27). We have followed that story from a garden to a cross to an empty tomb to a church spreading across the world. Now we come to the last book of the Bible, and to the end of the story.

Many people are afraid of Revelation, or fascinated by it for the wrong reasons. It is full of strange images: beasts, dragons, trumpets, bowls, a woman clothed with the sun. Christians who love the Bible have read its details in different ways for two thousand years. But its main message is not hard to see, and it was written to comfort suffering Christians. Jesus wins, evil is judged, and God comes to live with his people forever.

Revelation was written by the apostle John, an old man exiled on the island of Patmos "on account of the word of God and the testimony of Jesus" (1:9). Most scholars date it around AD 95, late in the reign of the emperor Domitian, though some place it in the late 60s under Nero. Either way, the cities of the region honored the emperor as a god, and Christians who would not join in paid a price. Small churches in what is now western Turkey were wondering who was really in charge of the world. Revelation pulls back the curtain and shows them.

The Word: Revelation

> **Revelation 1:1, 3** *"The revelation of Jesus Christ, which God gave him to show to his servants the things that must soon take place.... Blessed is the one who reads aloud the words of this prophecy, and blessed are those who hear, and who keep what is written in it, for the time is near."*

ἀποκάλυψις *(apokalypsis, "revelation")*

an unveiling; a pulling back of the curtain

apo	+	kalyptō
"away from"		*"to cover"*
Taking something off.		A veil or a covering.

Payoff: "Apocalypse" has come to mean disaster and the end of the world. In the Bible it means an unveiling. Revelation pulls back the curtain on what is really happening behind the headlines: the risen Christ reigns, heaven worships, and history is moving toward his return. It is "the revelation of Jesus Christ" in two senses: it comes from Jesus, who received it from God to show to his servants (1:1), and it reveals Jesus himself. The book is a promise of blessing to those who read it, hear it, and keep it, not a code to crack.

Part One: The King Among His Churches



"I, John, your brother and partner in the tribulation and the kingdom and the patient endurance that are in Jesus, was on the island called Patmos" (Rev. 1:9).

John was "in the Spirit on the Lord's day" when he heard a voice behind him and turned. He saw the risen Jesus in blazing glory, his eyes "like a flame of fire" and his face "like the sun shining in full strength." John fell at his feet as though dead. "But he laid his right hand on me, saying, 'Fear not, I am the first and the last, and the living one. I died, and behold I am alive forevermore, and I have the keys of Death and Hades'" (1:10–18).

That is the first thing a suffering church needed to hear. The One who holds the keys of death is the same Jesus who laid his hand on John. Then Jesus spoke to seven real churches (chapters 2–3). Some he praised for faithfulness under pressure. Others he rebuked. To Ephesus he said, "I have this against you, that you have abandoned the love you had at first" (2:4), and Laodicea was lukewarm. To all of them he promised a reward for the one who conquers. And to lukewarm Laodicea he said words that still hold for anyone who has shut him out: "Behold, I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, I will come in to him and eat with him, and he with me" (3:20).

Part Two: The Throne and the Lamb

Then John saw a door standing open in heaven, and he was shown the throne room of the universe. Around the throne, heavenly beings cried day and night, "Holy, holy, holy, is the Lord God Almighty, who was and is and is to come!" (4:8). Whatever was happening on earth, the throne of heaven was not empty.

In the right hand of the One on the throne was a scroll sealed with seven seals, the scroll of God's plan for history. A mighty angel asked, "Who is worthy to open the scroll and break its seals?" No one in heaven or on earth was found worthy, and John "began to weep loudly." Then an elder said, "Weep no more; behold, the Lion of the tribe of Judah, the Root of David, has conquered." John looked for a Lion, and he saw "a Lamb standing, as though it had been slain" (5:2–6).

That is the center of Revelation and the center of the Bible. The Lion conquers as the Lamb. He wins by being slain. The living creatures and the elders fall down before him and sing: "Worthy are you to take the scroll and to open its seals, for you were slain, and by your blood you ransomed people for God from every tribe and language and people and nation" (5:9). Then myriads of angels join in, "Worthy is the Lamb who was slain" (5:12), and at last every creature in heaven and on earth and under the earth and in the sea answers with praise (5:13).



"Salvation belongs to our God who sits on the throne, and to the Lamb!" (Rev. 7:10).

Later John saw the result: "a great multitude that no one could number, from every nation, from all tribes and peoples and languages, standing before the throne and before the Lamb, clothed in white robes." Who are they? "They have washed their robes and made them white in the blood of the Lamb" (7:9, 14). The promise to Abraham, that in him all the families of the earth would be blessed, is fulfilled at last.

Part Three: The Battle and the Victory

The middle chapters of Revelation are the hardest to read. In waves of seals, trumpets, and bowls, they show war, famine, persecution, and God's judgments on a world in rebellion. They show the dragon, "that ancient serpent, who is called the devil and Satan" (12:9), and the beasts he uses: cruel empires and false religion that demand worship. Christians have understood the timing of these visions in different ways. What everyone can see is the pattern: evil is loud, but it is losing. The believers "have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony, for they loved not their lives even unto death" (12:11).

At the end, heaven opens and Christ rides out as "Faithful and True," and on his robe is written, "King of kings and Lord of lords" (19:11, 16). Every enemy is defeated, the devil included. Chapter 20 also speaks of a thousand years when Satan is bound and the saints reign with Christ. Faithful Christians read that "millennium" in three main ways: as the present age between Christ's first and second comings, as a coming golden age of the gospel before he returns, or as a reign on earth after he returns. All three agree on the main point, and you do not have to settle the rest to see it: Christ wins and Satan loses. Then comes the final judgment. John saw "a great white throne," and "the dead, great and small, standing before the throne." They were judged by what they had done. "And if anyone's name was not found written in the book of life, he was thrown into the lake of fire" (20:11–15).

This is sobering, and it should be. Revelation does not pretend that everyone will be saved. Judgment is real, and it is just. Notice that two kinds of books are opened. The books of deeds tell the truth about every life, and on their own they condemn us all. Then there is another book, "the book of life of the Lamb who was slain" (13:8). No one's name is written there because of their record. It is written there because the Lamb was slain for them, and the good they did only shows that they truly belonged to him. Everyone who is saved will be saved by his blood. If you belong to the Lamb, you do not need to dread that day. The city is open to "those who are written in the Lamb's book of life" (21:27).

Part Four: All Things New

Then the curtain rises on the last scene of the Bible.

> **Revelation 21:1–4** *"Then I saw a new heaven and a new earth, for the first heaven and the first earth had passed away, and the sea was no more. And I saw the holy city, new Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, prepared as a bride adorned for her husband. And I heard a loud voice from the throne saying, 'Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man. He will dwell with them, and they will be his people, and God himself will be with them as their God. He will wipe away every tear from their eyes, and death shall be no more, neither shall there be mourning, nor crying, nor pain anymore, for the former things have passed away.'"*

Notice the direction. Heaven comes down. When believers die, their souls go to be with Christ, but that is not the end of the story. The final hope is a renewed world, with raised bodies, where God lives with his people. When John says the first heaven and earth "had passed away," he means the old order of sin, curse, and death is gone. God does not throw away the world he made. Paul says "the creation itself will be set free from its bondage to corruption" (Rom. 8:21), and here God says, "Behold, I am making all things new" (21:5). The Bible ends where it began, with heaven and earth, a river, and the tree of life. But the garden has grown into a city, filled with people from every nation. Only now there is no serpent, no curse, and no sword guarding the way.

The Bookends of the Bible



"Behold, I am making all things new" (Rev. 21:5).

And at the center of it all: "the river of the water of life, bright as crystal, flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb." On either side grows "the tree of life," and its leaves are "for the healing of the nations. No longer will there be anything accursed, but the throne of God and of the Lamb will be in it, and his servants will worship him. They will see his face" (22:1–4).

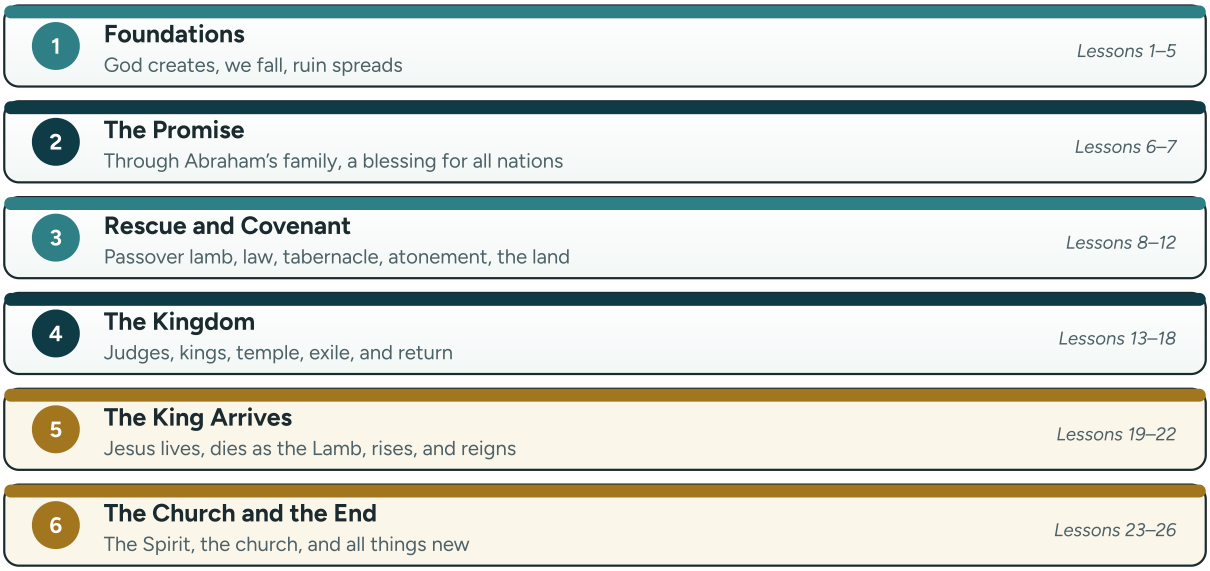
They will see his face. Adam and Eve hid from God's presence among the trees. Moses was told no one could see God's face and live (Ex. 33:20). Now the people of God look on him with nothing between. That is what we were made for.

THREAD WATCH: THE THREADS COME HOME

THE LAMB From the garments of skins in Eden, to Abraham's "God will provide for himself the lamb" on Moriah, to the Passover and the Day of Atonement, every covering and every sacrifice pointed forward, until John the Baptist said, "Behold, the Lamb of God," and Jesus died on the cross. In the original Greek, Revelation calls Jesus "the Lamb" twenty-eight times. The last we see of him, he is on the throne: "the throne of God and of the Lamb" (22:1, 3).

GOD WITH HIS PEOPLE God walked with Adam in the garden. He lived in a tent in the desert and a temple on Moriah. He "became flesh and dwelt among us" (John 1:14). He lives in his church by the Spirit. And at the end, "I saw no temple in the city, for its temple is the Lord God the Almighty and the Lamb" (Rev. 21:22). The whole new creation is his dwelling place. The two threads that began in Genesis meet at one throne.

The Whole Story in Six Units



Two threads, one ending: "the throne of God and of the Lamb" (Rev. 22:3).

CORE DOCTRINE 26 OF 26

Christ's Return and the New Creation

Jesus will return bodily and visibly in glory. He will raise the dead, judge the world in righteousness, and make all things new. Those who belong to him will live forever with God in a renewed creation, and those who refuse him will go away into eternal punishment under his just judgment (Matt. 25:46).

KEY VERSES

Acts 1:11; 17:31; 1 Thessalonians 4:16–17; Revelation 21:1–5

WHAT THE CHURCH CONFESSES

"From thence he shall come to judge the quick and the dead." (Apostles' Creed ("the quick" means "the living"))
"At the resurrection, believers, being raised up in glory, shall be openly acknowledged and acquitted in the day of judgment, and made perfectly blessed in the full enjoying of God to all eternity." (Westminster Shorter Catechism 38)

WHY IT MATTERS

History is going somewhere. The story that began in a garden ends in a city where God lives with his people, and you are invited.

The Turn: Come

The Bible's last invitation is one word, repeated: "The Spirit and the Bride say, 'Come.' And let the one who hears say, 'Come.' And let the one who is thirsty come; let the one who desires take the water of life without price" (22:17).

The Bride is the church, the people the Lamb loved and bought with his own blood. God's Spirit and God's people are both calling you. Without price. After twenty-six lessons, that is still the heart of it. You cannot buy your way into the new creation, and you do not need to. The Lamb has paid. If you are thirsty, if you know you are a sinner, if you are tired of a world full of tears and death, come to Christ. Turn from your sin, trust him, and take the water of life as a gift.

And if you already belong to him, live as someone who knows how the story ends. Jesus said, "Surely I am coming soon." John answers for the whole church, "Amen. Come, Lord Jesus!" (22:20). If "soon" sounds strange after two thousand years, Peter explains that God does not count time the way we do, and that every day of delay is his patience, giving more people time to repent (2 Pet. 3:8–9). No one knows the day or the hour (Matt. 24:36), so we do not waste our time guessing. We worship the Lamb, we hold on through suffering, we love his people, and we tell others to come. The whole story ends with a wedding feast. "Blessed are those who are invited to the marriage supper of the Lamb" (19:9). You are invited.

Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1. **Read the ending.** Read Revelation 1, 4–5, and 21–22 this week. Read them aloud if you can (Rev. 1:3).
2. **Worship the Lamb.** Sing or pray Revelation 5:12 back to God each day.
3. **Grieve with hope.** Bring one sorrow to God and read Revelation 21:4 over it.
4. **Check your first love.** Ask honestly whether your love for Christ has cooled (Rev. 2:4), and return to him.
5. **Say "Come."** Invite one person to read the Bible with you or to come to church with you.
6. **Memorize Revelation 21:3.** "Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man. He will dwell with them, and they will be his people, and God himself will be with them as their God."

Where to go from here: *You have walked the whole Bible. Now read it for yourself, a chapter a day: the Gospel of Mark, then Genesis, then Romans, with a psalm each day to pray. Join a church that preaches the whole Bible, and if you have come to trust Christ through these lessons, tell the pastor and ask about being baptized. Find one older Christian who will read with you and answer your questions. And come back to Lesson 1, "The Story Jesus Told," and read Luke 24 again. It will mean more now.*

For Discussion

1. What did you think Revelation was about before this lesson? What surprised you?
2. Why did John need to see the risen Jesus before he saw anything else?
3. The Lion conquers as the Lamb. What does that tell us about how God wins?
4. How should the reality of final judgment shape the way we live and speak to others?
5. Heaven comes down to earth in Revelation 21. How is that different from what most people imagine?
6. Which of the "no more" promises of Revelation 21:4 means the most to you right now?

7. Looking back over all twenty-six lessons, what is the most important thing you have learned about God's story?

Sources & For Further Study

- On the last things: Westminster Confession of Faith 32–33; Westminster Shorter Catechism 37–38.
- On Revelation: Dennis E. Johnson, *Triumph of the Lamb*; Vern S. Poythress, *The Returning King*; G. K. Beale, *Revelation: A Shorter Commentary*.
- On the new creation: Randy Alcorn, *Heaven*; Anthony A. Hoekema, *The Bible and the Future*.
- On the millennium, with each view argued by its own advocate: Darrell L. Bock, ed., *Three Views on the Millennium and Beyond*.



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